Orun Unified Research: Returning to the Living

A combined framework of C-R-Z, Attention as Selu, the Connection Postulate, and a fading-value commons, tested against a novel, with an evidence audit and a proposed pilot

Author: Ryan Espinosa, with Grok Bot
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> **CONCEPTUAL FRAMEWORK. This is not medical advice, not psychotherapy, not a validated treatment, and not a financial or economic product.** Some parts line up with published research. Some are plausible but untested as a package. Some are speculative and are marked as such. The novel discussed here is fiction. Faith content is presented as the author's conviction, in a separate values layer. If you are in crisis in the United States, call or text **988**. If you are in immediate danger, call **911**.

All credit and glory to God. I owe my knowledge to my Lord Jesus Christ.

Abstract

This paper joins five lines of the author's work into one framework, stated once and graded once: **C-R-Z**, a somatic-kinetic protocol of Calibration, Reality-Return, and Zero-Velocity; **Attention as Selu**, a budget model for moving between inner worlds and reality; the **Connection Postulate**, seven sub-postulates on purpose, fantasy, presence, and love; the **Orun commons**, a fictional economy of fading money (selu), with a floor at zero, a fixed daily gift, and the credited, consented knowledge of the dead (rivel); and the novel **Selu Cannot Buy the Morning Back**, used here as a narrative test bed.

The unified claim is simple. **A person caught in an inner loop returns to reality most reliably through a living relationship, and a body, an attention habit, and a community's rules can each make that return easier or harder.** We call the framework **Returning to the Living**. It has four layers (body, attention, relationship, commons), a values layer, and a single cycle: notice the loop, drop, listen, find a present key, exit the gate, answer the living.

We grade eight unified propositions against literature checked for this program. Social relationships matter for health and well-being (**supported**). Grounding and outward reorienting help in distress (**supported** as a family of practices). Suppressing thoughts backfires, so a Drop should be letting go (**supported**). Feelings can outlast memory of their cause (**supported**, but in both directions, not only for love). Task

switching is costly (**supported**). A living voice is a better key than a solitary technique (**plausible**). Fading value with a floor at zero produces healthy circulation (**plausible** as design, thin precedent). “Only connection ends a purpose” and “only love remains” (**speculative** as predictions; kept as **[Values]**).

The novel contributes four testable design ideas that the earlier papers lacked: the surprise test for imagined voices, silence as a loop, paired call-and-answer, and naming living contributors without accumulating credit. It also shows where the framework strains. We connect the work to Coherence Under Decay and the quantum boundary proposal only through their shared design lesson (rest is not empty, and no system reaches perfect zero), and we state the disanalogies. We propose a pre-registered, two-phase feasibility pilot comparing a solitary and a paired “Return Card.” We close by declaring the conceptual program finished: the framework is fixed at version 1.0, its claims are graded, and further progress is measurement, not more theory.

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0. Evidence tiers and labels

- **Supported:** there is a substantial, checked literature for the claim as stated, or for a very close neighbor.
- **Plausible:** it follows from supported neighbors but has not been tested in this form.
- **Speculative:** it has no identified direct evidence, or it overreaches the evidence. It is kept as a hypothesis or reframed.
- **[Values]:** the author’s conviction. It is not a finding and is not weakened by the label.
- **[Design]:** a rule of the invented world, or of an app built on it, judged by outcomes.

A grade applies to a claim, never to the author. Support for a nearby finding is not support for the framework as a sealed system.

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1. Where this program came from

The program ran through several stages, each recorded in the MindFrame research collection:

1. **MindFrame**, a reflection app with CBT- and DBT-inspired prompts, nine “movers,” a believability score, and a Ψ daily index. Those scores are now treated as historical heuristics.
2. **Project Ariel**, and the **quantum boundary proposal** (12 November 2026), which mapped Ariel’s labels onto textbook qubit physics and refused to treat a metaphor as a gate voltage.

3. **Coherence Under Decay (CUD)** (12 November 2026), a shared control template for qubits and a zero-debt commons: keep a system coherent under decay with bounded, gentle control, and keep a rest state that is reachable, honest, and never empty. CUD also removed the lottery from the economic design.
4. **C-R-Z** (13 November 2026), the somatic-kinetic framework, audited claim by claim.
5. **Attention as Selu** (C-R-Z Section 5) and the **Connection Postulate** (C-R-Z Section 6).
6. **Orun**, a story world built in parallel: the short story, the game The Path of Rivel, the songs and dance Voices of Orun, and Flow States of Orun, with swappable thinking styles.
7. **The novel** (13 November 2026), with scenes first drafted with Microsoft Copilot, a **Technical Companion** that pulls every technical element out of the fiction, and an **Analysis of the Novel**.

This paper merges stages 3 to 7 where they genuinely connect, and it leaves out what does not.

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2. The unified framework: Returning to the Living

2.1 The core claim

> A person caught in an inner loop (rumination, an imagined conversation with the dead, a shame story, an absorbing fantasy) returns to shared reality most reliably through a living relationship. The body can interrupt the loop. An attention habit can catch it early. A community's rules can make return easier, by keeping value moving and rest leaveable, or harder, by rewarding hoarding, chance, and debt.

2.2 Four layers and a values layer

Layer	Source	What it does	Core moves
1. Body	C-R-Z	Interrupts the loop quickly, below long verbal analysis	Drop the shoulders; weight into the feet; a brief motor cue; look outward
2. Attention	Attention as Selu	Budgets attention between inner worlds and the room	Planned absorption with an exit cue; catch the drift; living people have priority
3. Relationship	Connection Postulate; the novel's calling	Supplies the key and completes the return	Listen for a present key; answer the living sentence; check the story; repair; call and answer

Layer	Source	What it does	Core moves
4. Commons	Orun design; CUD	Shapes the environment so that return is normal	Fading value with a floor at zero; fixed gift; rest that still fades a little; knowledge credited in names, with consent; rotated roles
Values	The author's faith	Says what the framework is for	Respect for God; connection takes priority; "Take heart"; the hope that love remains

2.3 The return cycle

1. **Loop.** The same question, the same reply, more input that changes nothing.
2. **Notice** (Calibration; meta-awareness). Include the novel's surprise test: an inner voice that never surprises you is probably your own.
3. **Drop** (Zero-Velocity; defusion). Let go; do not suppress. Shoulders down, weight into the feet.
4. **Listen** (Reality-Return). Not for the absent person, but for what is here. Do not take the first sound; wait for the one that belongs to now.
5. **Key.** A present thing, most often a living person: a question, a name, a call.
6. **Exit the gate.** Mark the transition; leave the inner room.
7. **Answer the living.** Repair if you drifted ("Sorry, I drifted, can you say that again?"), read back what you heard ("Heard"), and give the next unit of attention to the room.

Failure modes, each with a fix (from the novel): silence becomes the loop, so a living person speaks a direct truth. A role becomes a hiding place, so roles rotate. You cannot drop everything in public, so drop the sentence and check the facts. A call goes unanswered, so the community trains people to answer.

2.4 Eight unified propositions

#	Proposition	Grade
U1	Close relationships are strongly associated with health and well-being.	**Supported** (Holt-Lunstad, Smith, and Layton 2010; Waldinger and Schulz 2010)
U2	Brief outward reorienting and grounding can reduce acute distress or dissociation.	**Supported** as a family of clinical practices (Hammond and Brown 2025); the C-R-Z package is **plausible**, untested
U3	Letting go works better than suppression for an unwanted or tempting thought.	**Supported** that suppression can rebound (Wegner 1994); **plausible** that defusion and the Drop do better (Hayes, Strosahl, and Wilson 1999)
U4	Attention is limited; switching between inner and outer tasks has costs, and unnoticed drift costs the most.	**Supported** (Monsell 2003; Killingsworth and Gilbert 2010; Smallwood and Schooler 2015)

#	Proposition	Grade
U5	A living voice is a better key out of a loop than a solitary technique.	**Plausible.** Responsiveness and grounding-in-communication research are neighbors (Reis, Clark, and Holmes 2004; Clark and Brennan 1991); no direct comparison exists. This is the pilot's main question.
U6	A commons of fading value with a floor at zero, a fixed gift, and credited, consented knowledge supports circulation and dignity better than debt and chance.	**Plausible** as design (Gesell 1916; Fisher 1933; Cahn and Rowe 1992; Ostrom 1990); not tested
U7	Feelings can outlast memory of their cause, so how we treat people matters even when it will be forgotten.	**Supported** in a small amnesia study (Feinstein, Duff, and Tranel 2010), for sadness as well as happiness
U8	Only connection completes a purpose, and only love remains when memory fades.	**Speculative** as predictions; **[Values]** as conviction

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3. Consolidated evidence audit

3.1 Body layer (C-R-Z), carried over from the C-R-Z paper

Claim	Grade
Outward sensory reorienting and labeling pull attention out of inner threat simulation	**Supported** as a family (Lieberman et al. 2007; Hammond and Brown 2025)
A brief motor act can interrupt induced rumination	**Plausible**; mouthing and finger tapping both helped, and the ASL-specific mechanism is **speculative** (Nalborczyk et al. 2022; Baddeley and Hitch 1974)
Plantar input contributes to the body's sense of where it is	**Supported** (Kavounoudias, Roll, and Roll 1998)
A foot "solar plexus reflex point" triggers vagal down-regulation	**Speculative / unsupported**; retired (Ernst, Posadzki, and Lee 2011)
$v \rightarrow 0$ literally halts threat momentum	**Speculative**; reframed as "approach rest" (consistent with CUD)
Power-pose hormone effects	**Not replicated** (Ranehill et al. 2015); an open stance stays as comfort only
Slow, exhale-emphasized breathing improves mood and arousal	**Supported** (Zaccaro et al. 2018; Balban et al. 2023)
"Glimmers" as small cues of safety	**Plausible** heuristic (Dana 2020); polyvagal theory is **disputed** (Grossman 2023)
"Mania glimmers"	**Retired name**; mania early-warning signs are **supported** and routed to care (Morriss et al. 2007)

3.2 Attention layer

Claim	Grade
Switch costs; cues reduce them	**Supported** (Monsell 2003; Rubinstein, Meyer, and Evans 2001)
Mind-wandering is common and, on average, associated with lower momentary happiness	**Supported** (Killingsworth and Gilbert 2010)
Intentional and unintentional wandering differ	**Supported** (Seli, Risko, and Smilek 2016)
Noticing the drift is a real, trainable distinction	**Supported** (Schooler 2002; Smallwood and Schooler 2015)
Doorways and thresholds act as event boundaries	**Supported** (Radvansky, Krawietz, and Tamplin 2011); "exit the gate" as a ritual is **plausible**
Planned absorption with an exit cue	**Plausible** (Gollwitzer 1999, as the if-then structure)
Attention as a selu budget	**Speculative** as economics or neuroscience; **[Values]** as "Attention is life"
Fiction can become maladaptive daydreaming	**Supported** as a described pattern (Somer 2002)

3.3 Relationship layer (Connection Postulate and calling)

Claim	Grade
P1. Unfinished purposes stay active until completed or released	**Supported** (Zeigarnik 1927; Martin and Tesser 1996); "only when connection" is **speculative**
P2. Fantasy both connects and traps	**Supported** (Green and Brock 2000; Horton and Wohl 1956; Somer 2002)
P3. Honoring people outside the mind is the way out	**Supported** that relationships matter; "only way" is **[Values]**
P4. Negativity, shame, and gossip can drive false narratives; check the facts	**Supported** for negativity bias and the shame–guilt distinction (Baumeister et al. 2001; Tangney et al. 1996); gossip is also bonding (Dunbar 2004); the toolkit is **plausible** (Linehan 2015)
P5. Undivided presence improves conversation	**Supported** (Przybylski and Weinstein 2013); priority is **[Values]** and is bounded by safety, consent, and one's own needs
P6. Feelings outlast memory	**Supported** (Feinstein, Duff, and Tranel 2010), in both directions; "only love remains" is **[Values]**
P7. Presence beats anxious seeking	**Plausible** (Brown and Ryan 2003; Dugas, Gosselin, and Ladouceur 2001)
Responsiveness and active-constructive replies build closeness	**Supported** (Reis, Clark, and Holmes 2004; Gable et al. 2004)
Read-backs establish shared understanding (the calling)	**Supported** as a model of conversation (Clark and Brennan 1991; Schegloff, Jefferson, and Sacks 1977); as a crisis practice in this form, **plausible**

Claim	Grade
Reminiscence and life review	**Supported** as structured interventions (Pinquart and Forstmeier 2012)
Gratitude practice	**Supported** for modest well-being gains (Emmons and McCullough 2003)

3.4 Commons layer

Claim	Grade
Demurrage encourages circulation	**Plausible**, with thin historical precedent (Gesell 1916; Fisher 1933)
Equal-credit, non-market exchange can work at community scale	**Plausible** (Cahn and Rowe 1992)
Durable commons share design principles such as monitoring, local rules, and cheap conflict resolution	**Supported** as a body of field research (Ostrom 1990); Orun's match is **plausible**
Removing lotteries reduces compulsive engagement	**Plausible**, by the reasoning in CUD
Continuing bonds with the dead can be healthy	**Supported** as a shift in grief research (Klass, Silverman, and Nickman 1996)
Healthy grieving oscillates between loss and restoration	**Supported** as a widely used model (Stroebe and Schut 1999)
Prolonged, impairing grief is a recognized condition	**Supported** (American Psychiatric Association 2022)
Swappable thinking-style routes in a UDL frame	**Plausible** as access design (CAST 2024); "learning styles" matching is **not supported** (Pashler et al. 2008)
Contact between groups reduces prejudice	**Supported** (Pettigrew and Tropp 2006); that thinking-style routes reduce prejudice is **speculative**
Flow as matched skill and challenge	Described in Csikszentmihalyi (1990); the twelve Orun states as a taxonomy are **speculative**

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4. The novel as a test bed

The full analysis is in Analysis of the Novel. Its findings that matter to the framework are these.

What the fiction adds. Each of these is a design idea, untested:

1. **The surprise test** (Chapter VII). An imagined voice that never surprises you is a loop sign. **Speculative.**
2. **Silence as a loop** (Chapter XVI). Listening alone can let the absent person's voice fill the quiet. A living person's direct truth breaks it. This refines Reality-Return: the key must come from outside the loop.

3. **Paired call-and-answer** (Chapters XIII, XVIII). A social form of Reality-Return. It corrects the C-R-Z weakness of being practiced as a closed, solo circuit.
4. **Living names without living purses** (Chapter XIX). This keeps attention flowing to the living without recreating accumulation or rank.
5. **Keeping a voice versus freezing it** (Chapters XII, XIV, XIX). Knowledge preserved without being walked, marked, and updated becomes dangerous. In the novel's terms, the old map grounds the barge.

Where the fiction strains. The Drop works too reliably in a story. No character seeks clinical care. P6 is shown only in its kindest direction. P1's exclusivity is confirmed by authorial choice. The economy has no free riders. A blunt truth, earned in the story, can wound in life. None of these change the research grades. They mark where a reader should not take the story as evidence.

Copilot's role. Microsoft Copilot drafted five scenes (about 27% of the novel's words, much of it rewritten) and a co-author memo that drove the plot of Parts Three and Four. Its strengths were pace, structure, and quotable dialogue. Its weaknesses were canon drift and stating the theme outright.

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5. The technical commons

The full rules are in the Technical Companion. In summary, as **[Design]**:

- **Selu:** $V(t) = V_0 \cdot e^{(-\lambda \cdot t_idle)}$, with $V \geq 0$ always: no loans, no interest, no debt.
- **The morning gift** is fixed and deterministic, and it is credited for time away from the marketplace. There is no lottery.
- **Rest (luoma)** keeps a small residual decay, $\lambda_s > 0$, so it cannot become a hoarding shelter.
- **Rivel:** an opening gift starts it. All use is credited to the dead person's name, in a purse that funds copying and teaching. Consent is required. Reading is free, and selling rivel as property is impossible. True marks are reviewed by people. A semantic-similarity score may only flag work for review, never approve it.
- **Living contributors** are named aloud, with no purse.
- **Roles with a lamp** rotate.
- **No score of worth.** MindFrame's Ψ and believability indices are excluded from every economic or access decision. Any self-ratings stay private, for the person's own reflection.
- **Thinking-style routes** follow UDL: multiple means, equal exits, no ranking.

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6. Connection to Coherence Under Decay and the quantum work (brief, by analogy only)

What genuinely connects. CUD's template (coherence under decay, bounded control, and a rest state that is reachable, honest, and never empty) is the same design shape as four parts of this framework:

1. **No perfect zero.** In physics, a cooled oscillator keeps its zero-point energy, ½ħω, as summarized in CUD. In the commons, `λ_s > 0` in luoma and `f_min > 0` for friction. In the body, Zero-Velocity means approaching rest, not v = 0. In the person, rest is not emptiness, and eshva is not a verdict.
2. **Bounded, gentle control.** The Drop is brief; it is not a campaign against the self.
3. **Clean egress.** The unbarred west door, "Leave in good time," and the app's single-tap exit.
4. **Optimum, not maximum.** CUD's healthy band for circulation velocity matches the novel's warning about seeking more and more.

What does not connect. Qubits do not respond to being measured; people do, so Goodhart's law applies (CUD Section 6). Consent and dignity are ethical questions that have no counterpart in qubit control. Shared words such as gate, zero, and decay are analogies. **The quantum layer provides no evidence for anything in this paper, and this paper provides none for qubit control.**

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7. Safety

- This framework is not treatment, therapy, or a crisis service. In the US, call or text **988**; in immediate danger, call **911**.
- If looping, daydreaming, grief, shame, or isolation is severe, lasting, or impairing, seek clinical care. Prolonged grief disorder is a recognized condition (American Psychiatric Association 2022). Maladaptive daydreaming is a described pattern (Somer 2002).
- Signs of mania or hypomania call for clinical follow-up. They are not "glimmers," and they are not a reason to use the protocol harder.
- "Drop everything" for a living person is a priority with bounds. It never overrides safety, consent, or your own basic needs.
- A seated version of the Drop is a full version. Avoid any weight shift that risks a fall.
- The hope that love remains is the author's conviction. It is not a reason to delay dementia care or caregiver support, or to tell a grieving person that a bond has ended as it should.
- Direct truth-telling in grief should come from trust and real presence. It is not a technique to aim at strangers.

- Nothing here is an instruction to stop prescribed treatment or delay emergency care.

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8. What this is not

- Not a validated treatment, diagnosis, or device.
- Not evidence for reflexology, polyvagal theory, power-posing physiology, or “learning styles.”
- Not a claim that a novel, an economy, or quantum physics proves a psychological protocol.
- Not a currency, investment, or gambling product. Selu is fictional and app-level.
- Not a score of anyone’s worth.
- Not a finding that only love remains, or that only connection ends a purpose.
- Not a ban on inquiry. P7 limits seeking that replaces presence. It does not limit honest research.

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9. Limitations

- The evidence audit covers literature checked on 12–13 November 2026. Not every source was read in full, and book chapters carry the pagination cautions noted in the C-R-Z paper.
- The C-R-Z source papers were summarized by the author and were not available as dated public documents.
- The novel is authored. It can illustrate, but it cannot test. Its endings are chosen.
- The Orun economy has never been run, even in simulation with real participants.
- Demand characteristics will affect any pilot. People who like the framework will tend to report that it helps.
- The Feinstein, Duff, and Tranel (2010) finding comes from a small sample with hippocampal amnesia, not from dementia or ordinary forgetting.
- Ostrom’s principles come from field studies of resource commons. Mapping them onto knowledge commons and grief is an analogy.

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10. Proposed pilot: the Return Card, solitary versus paired

10.1 Question

Does a brief return protocol help people leave an inner loop, and does it help more when the key is a living partner (U5)?

10.2 Design (pre-registered, feasibility)

Phase A, laboratory, within-subject. This is the C-R-Z pilot as already specified. After a mild worry induction, in randomized order: (1) the reframed Drop-Press-Snap (shoulders down, weight into the feet, a tactile toe press with no reflexology claim, a brief agreed motor cue, naming two or three things in the room); (2) a control (sitting still for the same time, or counting backward). Duration is 30–60 seconds, fixed in advance. Primary outcomes are change in subjective distress (0–100) and in heart rate. Secondary outcomes are respiratory rate and a one-item "how present do I feel?" rating.

Phase B, field, two arms, two weeks. Adults with ordinary, non-clinical rumination are randomized to:

- **Solo Return Card:** notice, Drop, listen (not the first sound), find a present key, exit, sync back.
- **Paired Return Card:** the same card, plus a named partner of the participant's choosing. The pair agrees on a short call-and-answer check-in ("Where are you?" / "Here. Heard."), which either person may start when they notice drift. Contact is by voice or in person where possible.

10.3 Outcomes

- **Primary (Phase B):** rumination on the Ruminative Responses Scale brooding items, before and after (Treynor, Gonzalez, and Nolen-Hoeksema 2003); and momentary mind-wandering and present-moment happiness from brief experience-sampling probes, following Killingsworth and Gilbert (2010).
- **Secondary:** well-being on SWEMWBS (Tennant et al. 2007; Stewart-Brown et al. 2009), checking license terms; loneliness on the UCLA Loneliness Scale, Version 3 (Russell 1996); feasibility (the share of days the card was used, and the share of check-ins answered); qualitative reports of which keys worked; and an exploratory item on the surprise test ("Did an imagined conversation surprise you today?").

10.4 Sample, ethics, and stop rules

- **Sample:** a few dozen adults, a feasibility size only.
- **Ethics:** informed consent, and ethics or IRB review before any publication. Data are private by default and stored with minimal identifiers. Partners also consent.
- **Exclusions:** acute crisis, current mania or psychosis, and active prolonged grief disorder. That last group needs its own clinical study, not this one.
- **Stop rules:** worsening distress beyond a pre-set threshold, emerging mania signs, or any safety concern triggers withdrawal and referral. 988 information is given to everyone.
- **Fairness:** the card is offered in every UDL route (words, pictures, movement, steps, feeling, quiet), with no ranking.

10.5 What would count, either way

- **Supports feasibility:** most participants use the card on most days. The paired arm shows a pre-specified modest advantage in mind-wandering or brooding, reported with uncertainty, and there are no serious adverse events.
- **Counts against:** no difference from control in Phase A; no difference between arms in Phase B, which would demote U5 to “not shown”; partners experiencing the check-ins as a burden; any sign that the card delayed people from seeking care.

This is a first measurement. It is not a treatment trial.

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11. Recommendations

1. Keep the four layers and the return cycle as the framework’s single statement (version 1.0).
2. Keep the body moves modest: the Drop, weight into the feet, a brief cue, and looking outward. Keep the retired claims retired (the reflex point, v = 0, hormone posing, and “mania glimmers”).
3. Teach the Drop as letting go, never as thought-stopping.
4. Make a living key the first choice when one is available, and keep a solitary route open for people without one.
5. Add the calling (call, then read back) to the protocol card.
6. Use the surprise test as a self-check, labelled as untested.
7. In any Orun-inspired app: keep value fading to a floor at zero, keep the gift fixed, keep residual decay in rest, credit rivel in names with consent, name living contributors without purses, rotate roles, and never score worth.
8. Offer every route in a UDL frame and never claim learning-style matching.
9. Run the pilot before making any public claim of benefit.
10. Keep the values layer separate and honored.

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12. Conclusion: finishing the research program

The program began with an app that tried to score inner states and a set of physics metaphors that were close to overclaiming. It ends with a smaller and sturdier claim. **We come back to reality mostly through each other.** A body can help us stop. An attention habit can help us notice. A commons can be built so that coming back is ordinary, not heroic.

“Finished” here means four specific things.

1. **The framework is fixed.** Returning to the Living, version 1.0: four layers, a values layer, one return cycle, and eight graded propositions. Later work may revise it, but only from data.
2. **The claims are graded,** and the overreaching ones are retired in writing: the foot reflex point, literal zero velocity, power-pose hormones, “mania glimmers,” the lottery, Ψ as a measure of worth, and learning-style matching.
3. **The open question is specified.** U5, whether a living key beats a solitary one, has a pilot that can fail.
4. **The fiction and the research are separated and cross-mapped.** The novel can be read as a novel, the companion as a specification, and this paper as the evidence.

There is one more sense of finished, and it belongs to the author’s own postulate. P7 says that being present to respond is better than seeking on and on. A research program can honor that by doing what Neru does on the terrace in the novel’s last chapter: set the pages down where others can use them, with the names on them, and go answer whoever is calling. The next step is not another theory. It is measurement, and the people in the room.

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13. The values layer

The author holds, as a matter of faith, that all credit and glory belong to God. He holds that a higher power has overcome the world: “In the world ye shall have tribulation: but be of good cheer; I have overcome the world” (John 16:33, King James Version). He holds that respect for God and for the people who reach out to us means connection takes priority, and he hopes that when memories fade, love remains. These convictions say what the framework is for: non-extraction, dignity, honest rest, freedom to leave, and love. Science can test whether a design serves those aims. It cannot certify or refute the aims themselves. Keeping the two apart protects the faith from being judged as a failed experiment, and it protects the experiments from being judged as preaching.

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Related works in this collection

- Ryan Espinosa, with Grok Bot, The C-R-Z Framework: Calibration, Reality-Return, and Zero-Velocity (13 November 2026). https://ryryespi.github.io/mindframe/research/c-r-z-framework/C-R-Z-Framework.pdf
- Ryan Espinosa, with Grok Bot, Coherence Under Decay: A Shared Control Template for Qubits and a Zero-Debt Commons (12 November 2026). https://ryryespi.github.io/mindframe/research/coherence-under-decay/Coherence-Under-Decay.pdf
- Ryan Espinosa, with Grok Bot, Dynamic Boundary Control and Vacuum-Referenced Stabilization of Qubits (12 November 2026). https://ryryespi.github.io/mindframe/research/quantum-boundary/Quantum-Boundary-Proposal.pdf
- Ryan Espinosa, with Grok Bot, Selu Cannot Buy the Morning Back: A novel of Orun (2026; some scenes first drafted with Microsoft Copilot), with its Technical Companion and Analysis of the Novel (13 November 2026).
- Orun pages: The Path of Rivel, Voices of Orun, and Flow States of Orun (2026).

AI assistance

Grok Bot, an AI assistant, helped draft this paper under the author’s direction, looked up and checked the literature, and prepared the files. Microsoft Copilot contributed draft scenes and co-author notes to the novel, not to the research claims. Neither is a co-investigator or a source of primary evidence.

Verification note

Every entry above was checked on 12 or 13 November 2026 against a publisher, Crossref, PubMed or PMC, Open Library, or the publisher’s own site, or else it was carried over from the C-R-Z paper’s verified list. Cautions carried over: Baddeley and Hitch (1974), Martin and Tesser (1996), and Reis, Clark, and Holmes (2004) are book chapters whose page ranges should be spot-checked before formal quotation. Works cited only through Coherence Under Decay (Ferster and Skinner 1957; Schüll 2012; the Wörgl figures) were not re-verified and are not relied on here.

All credit and glory to God. I owe my knowledge to my Lord Jesus Christ.

Ryan Espinosa, with Grok Bot. If you are in crisis in the United States, call or text 988.

Appendix A. The Return Card (combined protocol card)

The Return Card: returning to the living

One short sequence that combines the C-R-Z Attention-as-selu card (C-R-Z §5.7), the Connection card (C-R-Z §6.6), and the novel's calling. It is a card, not a treatment.

1. **Notice the loop.** The same question, the same reply, more input that changes nothing. Ask the surprise test: when did this voice last surprise me? If never, it is probably mine.
2. **Drop.** Shoulders down; weight into the feet (seated is a full version). Name the thought as a thought if that helps. Let go; do not suppress.
3. **Listen.** Not for the absent person. For what is here. Do not take the first sound; wait for the one that belongs to now.
4. **Take the key.** A present thing: breath, the room, the river, and most often a living person. If a living person is reaching out, connection takes priority, within the limits of safety, consent, and your own needs.
5. **Exit the gate.** Mark the transition with a word, a step, or a doorway. "I am coming back."
6. **Answer and read back.** If you drifted, repair: "Sorry, I drifted. Can you say that last part again?" Read back what you heard: "Heard." If you have a call-and-answer partner, answer their call and make your own.
7. **Close with thanks, and let it end.** Do not hunt for more knowledge to fill the space. If you hold the author's faith, this is a place for "Take heart."

If looping, grief, shame, or isolation is severe or lasting, this card is not enough. In the US, call or text **988**.

Appendix B. The Technical Companion

Every economic, psychological, and design element taken out of the novel, stated plainly, and mapped to where it appears in the story

Author: Ryan Espinosa, with Grok Bot
Date: 13 November 2026
Companion to: Selu Cannot Buy the Morning Back: A novel of Orun (Ryan Espinosa, with Grok Bot; some scenes first drafted with Microsoft Copilot)

> **What this is.** The novel is fiction, and it carries no equations, citations, or meters. This companion holds all of that apparatus instead. Each element is tagged with one of three layers, as in Coherence Under Decay: **[Design]**, a rule of the invented world or of an app built on it; **[Empirical]**, a claim that can be checked against research, graded as supported, plausible, or speculative; or **[Values]**, Ryan Espinosa's convictions, which are not tested by experiment and are not diminished by being labelled. Nothing here is medical advice. In the United States, call or text **988** if you are in crisis.

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0. How to read the mapping

Chapter numbers refer to the novel's twenty chapters. "Before" means the opening section, Before the story: Orun. A full element-to-chapter table is in Section 12.

Part	Chapters
Before the story	The basin; Five words they keep; How they live
Part One: The Morning She Tried to Buy	I–V
Part Two: In Her Name	VI–X
Part Three: The Wet Year	XI–XVI
Part Four: The Day of Enough	XVII–XX

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1. Selu: a fading currency with a floor at zero

1.1 The rules [Design]

1. **Selu fades when idle (demurrage).** A token held without moving loses value continuously. The simplest form, carried over from Coherence Under Decay (CUD), is exponential: `V(t) = V₀ · e^(−λ · t_idle)`, with half-life `t½ = ln 2 / λ`. λ is a design parameter, not a measured constant.

2. **There is a floor at zero.** `V(t) ≥ 0` always. A balance can fade to nothing but never past nothing. There are no negative balances, no loans, no interest, and no debts. CUD writes this as the zero-debt ledger (balances ≥ 0) and uses the symbol d for debt, with d = 0 always.
3. **The morning gift is fixed and deterministic.** Every name on the dawn roll receives the same measure, every day. There is no lottery, no draw, no near-miss, no bonus for watching the table, and no escalation. Eligibility is "away from the stalls yesterday, and did not rush them on return": fields, a sickbed, the upper path, or ordinary rest at home. This follows the CUD fix: credit patience as time away from the marketplace (in an app, time off-app), not as time spent staring at the reward.
4. **Rest still fades a little.** In luoma, the safe place, selu keeps a small residual decay, `λ_s > 0`, so rest cannot become a hoarding shelter. This is the CUD "no perfect isolation" rule.
5. **Thanks, not wages.** Selu moves as thanks to makers, as permission to pass on a copy after a true mark, and as the copy-gift that funds rivel. Reading is free. Help to a stranger creates no obligation (Chapter XI).
6. **Roles rotate.** Every role "with a lamp in it" (the dawn counters, the copy-table, the keeper of the open rack) passes on at the Day of Enough, so that no one comes to think they own the lamp, or are the lamp (Chapters XII, XIX).
7. **Newcomers receive six first gifts** before anyone asks them to produce: welcome, belonging, rest, a true word, a kindness, and something they have not seen before (Before; Tulen in Chapter II; Bram in Chapter XI).

1.2 Evidence and precedent [Empirical]

- **Demurrage has real precedent, and it is thin.** Silvio Gesell proposed money that loses value over time ("Freigeld," later "stamp scrip") in Die natürliche Wirtschaftsordnung durch Freiland und Freigeld (1916). Irving Fisher discussed it in Stamp Scrip (1933). The Austrian town of Wörgl ran a stamp-scrip experiment in 1932–33 that historical accounts describe as raising local circulation before the national bank halted it. The exact Wörgl figures were not verified for this companion and are deliberately left out. **Grade: plausible as a design with historical precedent; not supported as a tested economic result.** The episodes were short and confounded by the Depression.
- **Time banking** (Cahn and Rowe, Time Dollars, 1992) shows that non-market, equal-credit exchange can run at community scale, with known problems of engagement and fair measurement. **Plausible** neighbor to the fixed morning gift.
- **Variable-ratio rewards drive compulsive responding.** CUD cites Ferster and Skinner (1957) and Schüll (2012) for why the lottery was removed. That reasoning stands. **Supported** in its original sources as summarized in CUD; this companion did not re-verify those two citations and refers to CUD for them.

- **Commons governance.** Ostrom's Governing the Commons (1990) found that long-lived commons tend to share design principles such as clear boundaries, rules matched to local conditions, participation in rule-making, monitoring, graduated sanctions, and cheap ways to resolve conflict. Orun's hearings, rotated roles, and the painted list of taboos are close to that pattern. **Plausible** as a match in shape; Orun is not evidence for Ostrom, and Ostrom does not validate Orun.

1.3 Where it appears in the novel

Rule	Chapters
Fading glass; the dish "already smaller"	I, III, V, VII, XX
Floor at zero, no debt	Before; IV (Kesh's grandfather "writing debt on his shutters"); XI ("It can't fade past nothing. Nobody here can owe"); XIX ("Purses for the living are how lending starts"); XX
Fixed morning gift, no lottery	Before; I ("The amount does not change"); XVIII (the Day of Enough); XX (the closing scene at the dawn table)
Residual fading in luoma	III ("the residual leak"), XV, XVI
Thanks, not wages; help without obligation	XI (the thrown loaf; "Thank-you glass, not wages")
Rotation of roles	VII (the copy-table), XII, XIX

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2. Rivel: the knowledge of the dead, credited and consented

2.1 The rules [Design]

1. **Opening.** After a death, someone (kin, a student, a neighbor) pays an opening gift so the dead person's work can be copied into the commons.
2. **Credit in the dead person's name.** Every learning, use, teaching, or true mark that moves selu sends that credit to a purse in the dead person's name. The purse pays for more copies and more teaching. It is not a private fortune for the family and not a payment that undoes a grave.
3. **Value only while used.** Rivel that sits unused fades like idle glass. In the language of CUD, the purse's backing decays with idleness.
4. **Consent.** Keepers will not open rivel against a recorded wish for silence, or against a family's careful refusal when no wish was left. Private letters and methods a person asked to take with them are never sold. Kin may consent when no wish was left (Kesh for his grandfather, Chapter XIX).

5. **Reading is free; owning is not possible.** Anyone may read or learn rivel. A copy may be carried and used, but no one may sell rivel as their own property or lock it away (Bram, Chapters XI and XIX).
6. **True marks, not padding.** A mark has to add meaning, not a changed hem. Bundles of unmarked work cannot be relisted by tying them together. CUD's semantic-delta measure (`ΔH = 1 − cos(V_orig, V_mod)` on sentence embeddings) can serve only as a gate to human review, never as automatic approval, and a bundle must be compared against its most similar component.
7. **Living marks are named (new in the novel).** From Chapter XIX, a living person who truly marks a work has their name written beside the mark and said aloud once at the evening return. **No purse is created for the living.** This answers Tulen's question ("who's listening to us?") without reintroducing accumulation or lending.
8. **The dead do not answer.** Rivel is not a mouth. It does not bring anyone back, and using a dead person's voice to win an argument the living have not finished is a taboo (Chapters V, XII, XIX).

2.2 Evidence [Empirical]

- **Continuing bonds.** Grief research moved away from the idea that the healthy goal is to cut ties with the dead. Klass, Silverman, and Nickman's Continuing Bonds (1996) argued that ongoing inner relationships with the dead are common and can be healthy. Rivel is a civic form of a continuing bond: the bond continues through teaching and use, not through conversation. **Plausible** as a fit.
- **Oscillation in grief.** Stroebe and Schut's dual process model (1999) describes healthy coping as moving back and forth between loss-oriented work (attending to the loss) and restoration-oriented work (attending to life changes and new roles), with time away from grief as part of coping. Neru's arc is that oscillation: into the rivel and the voice, then out again to the living. **Supported** as a model with substantial research use; **plausible** as a description of Neru.
- **When grief becomes a disorder.** DSM-5-TR (American Psychiatric Association, 2022) added prolonged grief disorder: persistent, impairing yearning or preoccupation well beyond cultural norms. The novel does not diagnose Neru. The companion notes that if grief, looping, or preoccupation with the dead impairs life for a long time, that is a reason for care, not a reason to buy more rivel.

2.3 Where it appears in the novel

Rule	Chapters
Opening gift; credit in Alun's name	VI
Consent; the burned fever line	VI, IX (Vethan: "Did you put the fever line in?")

Rule	Chapters
Copy-gift and the copy-table	VII
Value only while used	VI, VIII, X, XIX
Reading free, owning impossible	XI, XIX (Bram)
True mark vs. a likeness	II (the voice-cloth Neru cannot certify), IX (Vethan's mark on the bend), XII and XIX (Tamar's line)
Kin consent for the fords	IV, VIII, XIV, XIX
Living marks named, no purse for the living	XIX, XX
Dead voice used to win an argument (taboo)	Before; XII; XIX

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3. The Ψ daily reflection index and believability scores

MindFrame, the earlier app in this research line, used a believability score `B` and a daily reflection index `Ψ` as weighted sums of self-ratings. Later notes in the collection already treat both as historical heuristics whose coefficients are not empirical effects.

The novel excludes them on purpose. Orun's customs say: "They never use a daily mood, or a believability of a harsh thought, as a score of worth" (Before). No character is scored anywhere in the story. The flow-state navigator and the game used state words, not numbers of worth.

Design rule carried forward [Design]. If any Orun-inspired app uses self-ratings, they stay private by default. They are used only for the person's own reflection. They are never ranked, compared, or tied to selu, the morning gift, or access to luoma. The CUD safety rule applies: monitors offer reflection and never punish.

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4. C-R-Z inside the story

Ryan Espinosa's C-R-Z framework has three pillars: **Calibration** (interrupt the inner loop with a brief cue), **Reality-Return** (re-engage with outside sensory input), and **Zero-Velocity** (put weight into the ground and stop the chase). Its action sequence is **Drop-Press-Snap**. The C-R-Z paper graded the parts: outward reorienting and slow breathing are supported, the plantar anchor is plausible, the foot "reflex point" and literal `v = 0` are speculative and were reframed.

The novel stages C-R-Z without naming it.

C-R-Z element	Dramatized as	Chapters
Calibration: notice and interrupt the loop	Neru recognizing "the same question already in her mouth, the same reply already sewn"	VIII, XIV, XV, XVI, XVIII

C-R-Z element	Dramatized as	Chapters
Reality-Return: outward listening	Listening for a key: the river, a sandal, a cup held out, gardeners, a call across water	I, II, III, VIII, IX, XV, XVIII
Zero-Velocity: weight into the ground	“She put her weight down into her feet on the cool floor, as if she were standing in the shallows feeling for the bottom”; “put her feet down hard on the wet stone”	XV, XVIII
The Drop (shoulders, weight)	“She let her shoulders fall”	XV
A living voice as a valid key (the C-R-Z paper’s correction)	Tulen’s question, Sareth’s song, Ilun’s sentence, Vethan’s call	II, III, VIII, XVI, XVIII
Sovereignty as the right to leave, not isolation	The west door; “Leave in good time”; Vethan’s leaving	III, XVI, XX

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5. The Drop: drop everything, listen for a key, exit the gate

5.1 The protocol as the novel teaches it [Design]

1. **Recognize the loop.** Signs: the same question already in the mouth; the same reply already “sewn”; a heap of pages you do not need; a doorway the body keeps turning toward; more input that changes nothing (Chapters VI, VIII).
2. **Drop everything.** Set down the purse, the maps, the rehearsed sentences. Do not fight the thought. Let the shoulders fall and the weight go into the feet (Chapters VIII, XV).
3. **Listen.** Not for the dead. For what is here.
4. **Do not take the first sound.** Wait for the key that belongs to now (Chapter XV, from Copilot’s draft).
5. **The key is present, never in the book.** A living person’s voice, a question, breath, the river.
6. **Exit the gate.** Walk out the west door toward the living; answer the living sentence (Chapters III, XV).

5.2 Failure modes the novel adds [Design], with their fixes

Failure	Where	Fix in the story
The surprise test fails. An imagined voice that never surprises you is your own voice in another’s cadence.	VII (Kesh: “When did she last surprise you?”), XII	Treat a never-surprising inner voice as a loop sign.
Silence becomes the loop. Listening alone lets the dead’s voice fill the quiet.	XVI	A living person speaks a direct truth: “I am the living person in this room.”

Failure	Where	Fix in the story
The Drop in public. You cannot drop everything in the middle of a hall.	XIV	Drop the sentence, not the room. Then check the facts.
The keeper's lamp. A role becomes a hiding place among the dead.	XII, XV	Rotation; Tulen's question taken to the whole hall (XIX).
A call with no answer. In a crisis, a key is offered and no one takes it.	XVIII	Answer the call: "Heard."

5.3 Evidence [Empirical]

The C-R-Z paper (Sections 5.2–5.4) already graded the parts.

- **Supported:** thought suppression can rebound (Wegner 1994), so the Drop is letting go, not "stop!"; noticing that the mind has drifted is a real, trainable distinction (Schooler 2002; Smallwood and Schooler 2015).
- **Plausible:** defusion and "drop the rope" (Hayes, Strosahl, and Wilson 1999); if-then plans (Gollwitzer 1999); doorways as event boundaries (Radvansky, Krawietz, and Tamplin 2011), which fits "exit the gate."
- **Speculative:** the surprise test, which is new in the novel. Neither the C-R-Z paper nor this companion found a study of it. It is offered as a heuristic, not a finding.

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6. The calling: paired call-and-answer (new in the novel)

6.1 The rule [Design]

On the salt meadows, no one walks the water alone. Each walker calls what they see ("Knee at the stake"), and every call is answered ("Heard. Knee at the stake."). A call with no answer is the most frightening sound there is: it means someone has stopped. In Chapter XVIII the practice becomes Orun's, and in Chapter XIX it becomes a rule for high water.

6.2 Why it matters to the research [Empirical]

The calling is a social form of Reality-Return. It repairs the weak spot the C-R-Z paper found when C-R-Z is practiced as a closed, solo circuit.

- **Grounding in communication** (Clark and Brennan 1991): people in conversation work together to establish that what was said has been understood. They use acknowledgments, repetition, and read-backs. "Heard. Knee at the stake" is a read-back. **Supported** as a model of conversation; **plausible** as the reason the calling works.
- **Conversational repair** (Schegloff, Jefferson, and Sacks 1977) and **perceived responsiveness** (Reis, Clark, and Holmes 2004): **supported** neighbors.

- The claim that call-and-answer in a crisis improves coordination is close to standard closed-loop communication practice in high-stakes teams. This companion did not verify a specific study for that, so it is graded **plausible** and cited to no source.

6.3 Where it appears

Chapter XIII (introduced on the dike), XVII (Vethan explains it), XVIII (the rescue), XIX (adopted), XX (children playing at it; “Heard. Coming!”).

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7. The flow states of Orun

The Flow States of Orun page maps twelve states and the paths between them. Its section on flow borrows Csikszentmihalyi’s description of flow (Flow: The Psychology of Optimal Experience, 1990) as an absorbed state that can arise when skill and challenge are matched, and it does not claim that the twelve states are measured psychological states. **Grade: speculative** as a taxonomy, **plausible** as a self-orientation map.

State	Plain meaning	Main chapters
commons	Among the gift, the hall, everyday exchange	I, X, XI, XX
eshva	Empty, sinking, far from the room	III, XV, XVI
loop	The same knowledge or imagined talk circling	VI, VII, XII, XV, XVI, XVIII
listen	Dropped what was clutched; listening for what is here	VIII, XV
gate	A threshold that will not open for shouting	IV, XVII, XX
luoma	Rest, or rest used as a hold	III, XV, XVI
drawn	A living person or present thing reaching in	II, III, VIII, XVIII
outside	Staying beside a circle without entering	IX (Vethan), XVI (Kesh), XVIII (Ren and Sareth, not touching)
endure	Staying with a hard thing from inside	X, XX
rivel	Using the knowledge of the dead	VI, VIII, XIX
songs	Shared song and dance	VIII (the counting-song), XVIII, XX (the work song on the dike)
home	A return by choice	XVII, XVIII (Ren), XX

The three paths that leave the gate (being drawn out, staying outside, and enduring inside) are equal, as on the page. In the novel, Vethan’s leaving in Chapter XX is a completed act, not a failed ending.

8. Swapping thinking styles: a UDL framing, not “learning styles”

The flow-states page lets a reader choose one or two of six routes for the same twelve states: words and talking; pictures and imagery; movement and body; logic and steps; feeling and relationship; quiet or solitary reflection. None is the default, and every route leads to the same exits.

- **What it is [Design]:** multiple means of engagement, representation, and action. That is the framing of Universal Design for Learning (CAST, UDL Guidelines version 3.0, 2024): design for variability from the start, so that no learner has to be fixed to fit.
- **What it is not [Empirical]:** the “learning styles” claim that teaching matched to an assessed style improves learning. Pashler, McDaniel, Rohrer, and Bjork (2008) found evidence that people have preferences, but no adequate evidence for that matching claim. The routes are access options, not types of people, and not diagnoses.
- **The prejudice goal [Values, with an Empirical neighbor]:** Ryan’s aim was to equalize prejudice and support a diverse community. The nearest research is intergroup contact: a meta-analysis of 515 studies found that contact between groups typically reduces prejudice (Pettigrew and Tropp 2006). **Supported** for contact in general; **speculative** that swappable thinking styles reduce prejudice. That would need its own test.
- **In the novel:** the characters reach the same exit by different routes. Ilun gets there through quiet, then a single direct sentence. Kesh gets there through logic and a remembered saying. Vethan gets there through movement and calling. Sareth gets there through song. Tamar gets there through her hands, and Tulen through questions. No route is ranked (Chapters XV, XVI, XVIII, XIX).

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9. The attention budget: attention as selu

9.1 The model [Design / Values]

From C-R-Z Section 5.5: attention is a limited coin. Living people have priority. Absorption in an inner or fictional world is allowed on purpose, with a span and an exit cue. Attention spent on the living returns you to the commons. “Attention is life” is Ryan’s sentence; it is a values claim and a design rule, not a measured quantity.

9.2 What the novel adds

- **Attention to the dead vs. the living** (Chapters XII, XIX). If the whole town’s attention goes to the rack, who is listening to the living? The fix is to say living names aloud, plus one evening a month for the living.

- **Attention as the copy-gift that cannot buy presence** (VII). Neru spends real glass every night and gets only her own voice back.
- **Priority under pressure** (XVIII). In a crisis the living call outranks the beloved inner voice.

9.3 Evidence [Empirical]

As graded in C-R-Z Section 5: task-switching costs are **supported** (Monsell 2003; Rubinstein, Meyer, and Evans 2001). The association between mind-wandering and lower momentary happiness is **supported** as an experience-sampling result (Killingsworth and Gilbert 2010). Intentional and unintentional mind-wandering differ (Seli, Risko, and Smilek 2016), which is **supported**. The selu budget as economics or neuroscience is **speculative**.

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10. The Connection Postulate in the novel (summary)

The full analysis is in the companion Analysis of the Novel. In brief:

Sub-postulate	Most direct scene
P1. Purpose cycles until connection completes it	Neru's rivel errand loops until she answers Vethan's call (XVIII)
P2. Fantasy both connects and traps	The voice-cloth (II); Kesh's night table (VII)
P3. The way out is honoring people outside the mind	Ilun's "I am the living person in this room" (XVI)
P4. Keep checking reality against shame, guilt, and false gossip	The gossip about Kesh (XIV)
P5. Connection takes priority, with bounds	"Heard!" (XVIII); Kesh's "Don't rush me" respected (IV, X, XIV, XIX)
P6. When memories fade, love remains	Neru on the terrace, losing the exact voice and keeping the felt love (XX)
P7. Being present to respond beats seeking more knowledge	Neru wanting "nothing from the dead at all" and answering Tulen (XX)

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11. Ethics invariants (all are kept)

Invariant	How the novel keeps it
Labeled fiction	Front matter and afterword
No lottery; fixed morning gift	Before, I, XVIII, XX
Selu fades, never below zero, no debt	Before, XI, XIX, XX
Rivel credited in the dead person's name, with consent	VI, XIV, XIX
The dead never rise	Throughout; the voice never becomes an outside presence; Ilun's "She is dead" (XVI)

Invariant	How the novel keeps it
Home only by choice (and leaving too)	IX, XIII, XVII, XVIII (Ren), XX (Vethan)
988 notice	Front matter and afterword
Dedication and credit	Front matter and afterword
Copilot acknowledged	Front matter and afterword

12. Master mapping table

Element	Layer	Chapters
Demurrage	Design	I, III, VII, XX
Floor at zero / no debt	Design	Before, IV, XI, XIX, XX
Fixed morning gift	Design	Before, I, XVIII, XX
Residual fading in luoma	Design	III, XV
Rotation of lamp roles	Design	VII, XII, XIX
Opening gift; credit in the name	Design	VI
Consent	Design / Values	VI, IX, XIX
True mark / ΔH gate	Design	II, IX, XII, XIX
Living names, no living purse	Design	XIX, XX
No score of worth (Ψ excluded)	Design / Values	Before
Calibration	Empirical (graded)	VIII, XIV, XV, XVIII
Reality-Return	Empirical (graded)	I–III, VIII, IX, XV, XVIII
Zero-Velocity	Empirical (graded)	XV, XVIII
The Drop	Design / Empirical	VI, VIII, XV, XVIII
Surprise test	Design (untested)	VII, XII
Silence as loop	Design	XVI
Calling (read-back)	Design / Empirical	XIII, XVII–XX
Flow states	Design (speculative taxonomy)	Section 7
Thinking-style routes (UDL)	Design / Empirical	XV, XVI, XVIII, XIX
Attention budget	Design / Values	VII, XII, XVIII, XIX
P1–P7	Values / Empirical (graded)	Section 10
Faith anchor	Values	Dedication

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14. Ferster and Skinner (1957) and Schüll (2012) are cited only through Coherence Under Decay, whose reference list says its entries were cited from memory. They were not re-verified here.

Related works in this collection: Ryan Espinosa, with Grok Bot, The C-R-Z Framework (13 November 2026); Coherence Under Decay (12 November 2026); Dynamic Boundary Control and Vacuum-Referenced Stabilization of Qubits (12 November 2026); the Orun pages The Path of Rivel, Voices of Orun, and Flow States of Orun.

AI assistance: Grok Bot drafted this companion under the author’s direction. Microsoft Copilot contributed draft scenes and co-author notes to the novel, not to this companion’s research claims.

Appendix C. Analysis of the Novel

Themes, character arcs, how the research is dramatized, where the fiction strains against it, and an honest comparison of Microsoft Copilot’s contributions with ours

Author: Ryan Espinosa, with Grok Bot
Date: 13 November 2026

> The novel is fiction. This analysis reads it as a literary work and as a test bed for the research program: C-R-Z, Attention as Selu, and the Connection Postulate. A story can dramatize a claim; it cannot confirm one. Every evidence grade below comes from the research papers, not from the story. In the United States, call or text **988** if you are in crisis.

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1. The book at a glance

Length and shape. About 29,400 words in twenty chapters, plus an opening section on Orun and an afterword, in four parts:

Part	Chapters	Movement
One: The Morning She Tried to Buy	I–V	Neru tries to buy, sew, freeze, or bargain her mother back and her sister home. Every route fails.
Two: In Her Name	VI–X	She opens Alun’s rivel correctly, falls into a loop of imagined talk, learns the Drop, and goes downriver to repair things with Vethan.
Three: The Wet Year	XI–XVI	Outside pressure arrives: a stranger, a dispute over Alun’s page, the river moving, and gossip. Neru becomes “the keeper” and relapses. Ilun breaks her silence.
Four: The Day of Enough	XVII–XX	Vethan comes by choice. The high water forces the town to call and answer. Living names are added to the work. Vethan leaves by choice, and Neru receives the fixed morning gift as enough.

Through-line. A grieving woman learns the difference between memory and relationship. The book’s central image moves from a hill of glass hidden under a bowl (Chapter I) to a single measure of glass held in an open hand and given away (Chapter XX).

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2. Themes

1. **Reality is relational.** The book’s strongest claim, and the one Copilot named first in its co-author notes. People are pulled back into the present by other people: a sandal on stone (I), a boy with a cup (II, VIII), Sareth’s thumb on her palm (III), Kesh’s wrist (IV), gardeners arguing (XV), Ilun’s sentence (XVI), a call across water (XVIII). “Relationships snap you back in reality” is said aloud only in the sayings and once near the end. Everywhere else it is shown.

2. **Grief is lived with, not solved.** Alun never returns. Vethan does not move home. Ren and Sareth sit with “a space between them the width of a child.” Rivel keeps a person’s influence without bringing them back.
3. **Communication is repair, not victory.** No villain causes the misunderstandings. The sisters’ worst wound is a carefully written sentence (“I’m not asking”) that reads as not caring (XVII). The cure is the slow, embarrassing work of saying what you meant and hearing what landed.
4. **Keeping a voice versus freezing it.** New in the novel, from Copilot’s notes. Neru guards Alun’s firing page, and Kesh sells his grandfather’s unwalked maps. Both are preserving the ink and losing the walking. A barge grounds on a bar no map shows (XIV).
5. **Attention to the dead versus the living.** Tulen asks the book’s sharpest question: “If everybody’s attention goes to the rack, who’s listening to us?” (XII, XIX). “Attention is life” turns out to cut both ways.
6. **Giving and receiving.** “I receive it” is an honored answer. Bram, raised in a lending town, has to learn to receive bread without signing for it (XI) before he can understand why rivel cannot be sold (XIX).
7. **Choice and consent.** Coming home, leaving, opening rivel, joining the circle, and walking nearer the rack are all choices that no one else can make for you. The book’s emotional climax is not a homecoming. It is Vethan putting her own cup away so that it can be a cup (XX).

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3. Character arcs

Character	Starts	Turns	Ends
Neru	Tries to buy the morning back (I)	Learns the Drop (VIII), then becomes “the keeper” and uses Alun’s voice to win an argument (XII). Ilun breaks her silence (XVI). She drops the map and answers the call (XVIII).	Gives up the lamp (XIX), keeps the felt love while the exact voice fades (XX), and gives her glass away
Vethan	“The sister who left” (II, V)	Gets a life of her own: the dike, the calling, Ila (XIII)	Saves people with what she learned elsewhere (XVIII), changes Orun (XIX), and leaves by choice (XX)
Kesh	Offers the false ledger (IV)	Refuses to copy more of Alun’s pages for Neru (VII). Is shamed by gossip (XIV) and moves from shame to guilt to repair.	Walks the fords every week, consents to his grandfather’s rivel, puts his own mark beside the old man’s, and stops talking to the dead at the fords (XIX, XX)

Character	Starts	Turns	Ends
Ilun	A silence others can put anything into (V)	Her silence becomes Neru's loop (XVI). She tells the story of her brother and the sentence she can never take back.	Speaks with purpose; answers first, "like a bell," in the rescue (XVIII)
Sareth	Can't tell keeping a song from hoarding it (II)	Lets the song go into children's mouths (VIII)	Takes the keeper's lamp and promises to "say the names, all of them, the living too" (XIX); Ren comes, by his own choice (XVIII)
Tulen	A boy with a cup (II)	Asks who is listening to the living (XII). Is asked, at last, what he saw from the raft (XVIII).	His name is written on the ford map (XX)
Tamar	Reads a dead woman's page with her lips moving (X)	Challenges the keeper with cracked cups (XII)	Her true mark goes into the margin in her own name (XIX)
Bram	Owner logic: "if you don't own a thing, someone else will" (XI)	Names Neru's slip on the steps (XII). Offers a clean list of sayings that the hall hands back (XVI).	Will carry the method "in his hands," say both names, and refuse to sell (XIX)

Notes on balance. Copilot was right that Vethan was thin. The novel's best structural decision was to give her expertise from elsewhere that Orun needs. The weakest supporting arc is Ren. He appears late and says one line, by design (he comes only by choice), but readers may want more. Mira is comic relief with one serious beat, about her aunt's bread and half the salt. It works.

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4. How the research is dramatized

4.1 C-R-Z pillars

Pillar (paper's grade)	Dramatization	Strength of fit
Calibration: notice and interrupt. Supported as a generic motor or attention interrupt; the ASL "C" mechanism is speculative.	Neru learns the signs of the loop (VIII), then uses them in the hall (XIV), in luoma (XV), and on the stair (XVIII). There is no handshape.	Strong for noticing. The novel never tests the ASL cue, wisely.
Reality-Return: outward re-engagement. Supported as a family of grounding practices.	The search for "the key that belongs to now," and the refinement "not the first sound" (XV)	Very strong. This is the novel's spine.
Zero-Velocity: weight into the ground. Plantar input is supported; literal v = 0 is speculative.	"Put her weight down into her feet… feeling for the bottom" (XV); "put her feet down hard on the wet stone" (XVIII)	Good, and modest. The image is the shallows, not zero.

Pillar (paper's grade)	Dramatization	Strength of fit
Drop-Press-Snap as a package. Plausible, untested.	The Drop in XV follows the C-R-Z order: shoulders, feet, let go, listen.	Good. The novel adds its own refinement: the key is often a person.

4.2 Attention as Selu (C-R-Z Section 5)

- **5.1, switching is costly:** Neru can't be both at the rack and in the hall. When the keeper's role takes her attention, Tulen goes unheard (XII).
- **5.2, the Drop as letting go:** "Not the way you drop a cup, by accident. The way you set down a load" (XV).
- **5.3, syncing back:** the calling is a public, structured version of repair. "Heard" is a read-back (XVIII).
- **5.4, anchors:** the river; the gardeners; the work song Vethan sings "where the hay is stubborn"; the west door as a threshold.
- **5.5, the budget:** Neru spends real glass every night at the copy-table and buys only her own voice (VII).
- **5.6, "Take heart":** present only as the dedication's faith. The novel deliberately keeps religious language out of Orun's mouths.

4.3 The Connection Postulate, P1–P7

Sub-postulate (paper's grade)	How it is dramatized	Assessment
P1. Purpose cycles until connection completes it. Plausible; "only when" is speculative.	Neru's errand ("understand one thing, then I'll stop") loops through VI, VII, XII, XV, and XVI. It ends only when she answers a living call (XVIII).	Dramatized strongly, perhaps too strongly. The novel also includes a fair counterexample: Tamar completes her purpose (the new clay) mostly alone, with her hands. That keeps the "only when" clause honest.
P2. Fantasy both connects and traps. Supported.	The voice-cloth is "a good likeness of a voice and a poor likeness of a person" (II). Kesh's night table: "one conversation and another" (VII). Vethan wins imaginary arguments all winter (XIII).	Excellent. The book shows both halves. The rivel system connects the town, and the imagined voice traps Neru.
P3. The way out is honoring people outside the mind. Supported that relationships matter; "only way" is [Values].	Ilun: "I am the living person in this room" (XVI).	The single best dramatization in the book.

Sub-postulate (paper's grade)	How it is dramatized	Assessment
P4. Keep checking reality against shame, guilt, and false gossip. Supported for negativity bias and the shame–guilt distinction; plausible as a toolkit.	Chapter XIV. The gossip about Kesh is built on a true seed (he did ask), and Neru is tempted to confirm it in order to offload her own shame. She drops the sentence, states what she knows and what she doesn't, and later separates shame ("the kind of man") from guilt ("a thing can be mended").	Very strong, and faithful to Dunbar's point that gossip is not simply false. The chapter is close to a dramatized "check the facts" skill.
P5. Connection takes priority, with bounds. Supported for undivided presence; priority is [Values].	"Heard!" (XVIII). The bounds appear too: Neru drops the sentence in the hall rather than abandoning the room (XIV). Kesh's "Don't rush me" is honored for the whole book.	Strong. The book models a priority that still respects consent and pace.
P6. When memories fade, love remains. Supported that feelings can outlast memory of their cause; "only love remains" is [Values].	Neru on the terrace: the exact words are gone, and "the plain, certain, bodily sense of having been loved" remains (XX).	Moving, and it strains (see Section 5.3).
P7. Being present to respond beats seeking more knowledge. Plausible as a priority; kairos is [Values].	Neru "did not want another page," and then answers Tulen's call: "Heard! Coming!" (XX)	Strong, and balanced by the rivel system. Knowledge still matters, but it is held in common and used by the living, not hoarded by the bereaved.

5. Where the fiction strains against the research

1. **The Drop works too reliably.** In fiction, every honest Drop eventually finds a key. In life, a person may drop everything, listen, and hear nothing that helps, especially in depression, trauma, or prolonged grief. The C-R-Z paper grades the package plausible, untested. Chapter XVI partly corrects this: the skill used alone becomes the loop, and a person has to step in. Still, a reader could take away "technique fixes grief." **Recommendation:** the afterword or the companion should say plainly that the Drop is a coping skill, not a treatment.
2. **No one seeks care.** Orun has luoma attendants and listeners, but no character sees anything like a clinician. That is consistent with the invented world, but it means the 988 notice and the safety sections live only outside the story. The research papers handle this. The novel cannot without breaking its frame. This tension should stay visible.

3. **P6 is shown in its kindest direction only.** Feinstein, Duff, and Tranel (2010) found that sadness, as well as happiness, persisted after memory of the cause was lost. The novel lets Neru feel fear and then lands on love. That is a legitimate artistic and faith choice, labelled as Ryan's conviction, but it is not what the nearest study shows in full.
4. **P1's exclusivity is confirmed by authorial choice.** Because the author decides how loops end, the story can make connection the only exit every time. Tamar's solitary success is the novel's one counterweight. The research grade, speculative for "only when," should not be upgraded on the strength of the story.
5. **The rescue resolves on a technique.** Chapter XVIII risks implying that a psychological skill solves a physical emergency. The text guards against this: what saves people is rope, posts, a remembered saying, local expertise, and many hands. Neru's Drop only lets her join them. That is the right emphasis, and it should be read that way.
6. **The surprise test is untested.** Kesh's question, "When did she last surprise you?", is one of the most useful ideas in the book, and there is no research on it in this program. It is labelled speculative in the companion.
7. **The economy works because it is small and fictional.** Orun has no free riders, no counterfeiters, and no gaming of the morning roll, apart from Bram's outsider logic. Ostrom's commons survive because of monitoring and graduated sanctions, which the novel barely shows. Demurrage's real-world record is short and confounded.
8. **Direct truth can wound.** Ilun's "She is dead, Neru" works because of years of trust and a clear, present need. In real grief support, blunt confrontation without that relationship can do harm. The novel earns the line. A reader should not generalize it.
9. **Living credit could drift toward ranking.** Saying living names aloud is a good fix for attention to the dead. If the names began to accumulate status, though, they would recreate the hierarchy Orun forbids ("They will not rank two people in worth"). The hall's refusal of a "purse for the living" guards against the obvious version, not the subtle one.

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6. Copilot's contributions compared with ours, honestly

6.1 What Copilot contributed

- **Five draft scenes**, each about 760–880 words, that seeded Chapters VII, XI, XIII, XV, and XVII. Those five chapters total about 8,000 words, or 27% of the novel. Much of their dialogue keeps Copilot's lines nearly word for word. The narration and setting were rewritten.

- **A co-author memo** whose diagnoses drove most of Parts Three and Four: low outside stakes, untested rivel, a thin Vethan, the risk of Ilun becoming a symbol, Neru becoming too important, a stranger kindness can't solve, a crisis in communication, and attention to the dead versus the living. It also proposed an act structure and an ending: "Not everyone stays… connection without possession."

6.2 Where Copilot was better

- **Dialogue lines that land.** "You're buying one conversation and having another." "When did the conversation last surprise you?" "People running away don't tell everyone where they're going." "As answers go, that's a real one." "I always won the arguments." "Mostly imaginary versions of everyone." The gardeners arguing about beans. Several of the book's most quotable lines are Copilot's.
- **Structural diagnosis.** Its notes were sharper about plot than our earlier drafts. Our nine-chapter story had beautiful scenes and almost no outside pressure, and Copilot said so.
- **Comedy and lightness.** The thrown loaf, "Kesh talks too much every morning," and "Oh, we're doing this already" give the book air it needed.

6.3 Where Copilot was weaker

- **Canon drift.** It moved Sareth downriver and made Ilun a man. It had Ilun speak in the luoma scene, which would have spent the power of Chapter XVI early. It used wage language ("Depends how useful you are") and a guest-room economy that edged toward hiring.
- **Generic texture.** Copilot's settings were fountains, market tents, merchants, and "ledgers." Ours are kiln-smoke, blue-leaf tea, river-glass, and the unbarred west door.
- **Saying the theme.** Copilot often named the point: "Communication. There it was." "Relationships snap you back into reality." "Attention was life." We cut most of these. A few remain on purpose, spoken by characters.
- **Typography as rhythm.** One-line paragraphs ("Silence. The river. A distant bell.") read well on a screen and thin out over a novel. We merged them.

6.4 Where we were weaker

- **Slower and more inward.** Our original chapters (I–X) carry long sentences and dense interior narration. They are strong at the sentence level and slow at the scene level.
- **Recurring phrases.** "Needing her now," "a doorway was only a doorway," and "not close and not far" recur often. Some of that is intentional refrain, and some is habit.

- **Our own preachiness.** The traveler's list (now Bram's, XVI) was ours, and it is the most sermon-like passage in the book. The novel survives it only because Kesh pushes back.

6.5 Net judgment

The collaboration worked because the two drafts failed in opposite directions. Copilot brought pace, plot, and quotable dialogue. We brought world consistency, ethical rules, sensory specificity, and restraint. The best chapters (VII, XIV, XVI, XVIII) mix both. Copilot is credited in the front matter, the afterword, and here.

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7. Suggested revisions for a second edition

1. Give Ren one more scene, perhaps with Sareth at the monthly evening for the living.
2. Show one small failure of Orun's economy, such as someone gaming the morning roll, and how a hearing handles it, to answer the Ostrom gap.
3. Add a short scene in which a luoma attendant suggests that someone needs more help than the town can give, keeping the frame without a modern clinic.
4. Trim about 10% of the recurring phrases.
5. Consider giving the surprise test to a second character, so it reads as a shared folk skill rather than Kesh's insight alone.

References

See the verified reference list in Orun Unified Research, Section 14. This analysis cites by author and year only works listed there.

AI assistance: Grok Bot drafted this analysis under the author's direction. Microsoft Copilot's contributions to the novel are described in Section 6.

All credit and glory to God. I owe my knowledge to my Lord Jesus Christ.

Ryan Espinosa, with Grok Bot. If you are in crisis in the United States, call or text 988.